

The King's Men



JAMES I OF ENGLAND

James I (1566–1625) was the only son of Mary Queen of Scots. He was crowned soon after Elizabeth's death but was unable to enter London to show himself to his subjects until March 15, 1604. He was kept away by a terrible new outbreak of the plague, which killed 30,000 Londoners and closed the playhouses for months. One of the new king's first acts was to make peace with Spain.

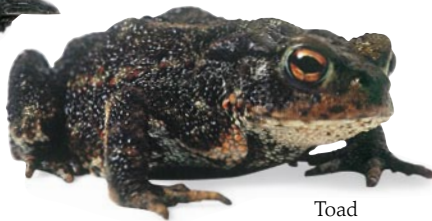


Crow



ROYAL TOUCH

These gold "touchpieces" were given by James to people suffering from a disease called scrofula. A royal touch was supposed to cure the disease. Kings and queens had been touching the sick since the 11th century, but the practice increased under the Stuarts.



Toad

FAMILIAR SHAPES

Witches were thought to have evil spirit helpers, called familiars, which took the shape of animals such as black cats, toads, and crows. James was obsessed with the threat of witchcraft and wrote a book on it called *Daemonologie*. He warned his readers of "the fearful abounding at this time in this country of detestable slaves of the devil, the witches." In the 17th century, hundreds of innocent people were hanged for witchcraft.



Black cat

QUEEN ELIZABETH DIED on March 24, 1603, and the crown passed to her closest male relative, James VI of Scotland. He was crowned James I of England on July 25, 1603, founding the Stuart dynasty. James found much about England unfamiliar. He disliked London and resented the power of the Puritan merchants. Supporting the theater was one way he tried to keep the Puritans in their place. He became the patron of Shakespeare's company, which was renamed the King's Men. The company was asked to perform at court more than 13 times a year, instead of the three times a year under Elizabeth. To please the king, Shakespeare wrote *Macbeth*, a tragedy with a Scottish setting.

Spear from Shakespeare's name



SHAKESPEARE'S ARMS

One sign of Shakespeare's growing success was that in 1596 he received a coat-of-arms, the badge of a gentleman. Later, when King James became patron of his company, Shakespeare was entitled to wear the uniform of the royal household.

NOBLE FROG

In the early 1600s, it became fashionable for courtiers to carry purses designed to look like unusual objects or animals, such as a bunch of grapes, a pair of bellows, or this frog. Although frogs were linked with witchcraft in *Macbeth*, they were also a symbol of spring, when ponds become full of noisy frogs.



Macbeth cries, "Hence, horrible shadow!" when he sees Banquo's ghost

The ghost of Banquo makes a terrifying appearance at a feast



MURDER AND TREASON

In *Macbeth*, the witches predict that the hero will be king of Scotland, but that his friend Banquo will be the father of kings. Macbeth murders King Duncan to seize the crown, then murders Banquo. King James believed he could trace his own family back to the noble Banquo, so he would have been flattered by Shakespeare's choice of subject matter.